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COMM 1315.001

10 October 2026

Caring for the Dead: Ma'nene in Toraja, Indonesia

1. The Practice, Its Origin, and Why It Is Taboo in America

Ma'nene is a ritual practiced by the Toraja, an ethnic group in the highlands of South Sulawesi, Indonesia. Families open the graves of relatives who died years or even decades earlier, take out the bodies, let them dry, clean them, and wrap them in fresh cloth or dress them in new clothes. Then the bodies go back into the tomb. Photographer and journalist Agung Parameswara (2015) reports that in the village of Pangala this happens in August, between harvest and planting, and that he saw relatives talking to the deceased and introducing them to newer members of the family.

The ritual comes from Aluk Todolo, the traditional Toraja belief system built around ancestor spirits. According to Parameswara (2015), a story about a hunter named Pong Rumasek, who prospered after he respectfully dressed and buried a body he found in the forest, taught people in his village that the dead deserve careful treatment, and that idea spread across the region. Putra et al. (2023), anthropologists at Hasanuddin University, add that the ritual began as a way to honor ancestors and ask for their blessing, but many Christian Toraja now understand it as an expression of love, gratitude, and care, since they believe blessings come from God alone. Their fieldwork also shows that it is not always held every year, because it depends on a family's money and willingness.

It is taboo in America because our norms around death are almost the opposite. Bodies are usually handled by professionals, sealed away, and never touched again, and disturbing a grave is a crime as well as something most of us find deeply disrespectful. Seeing relatives handle a corpse looks like a violation to many Americans, even though for the Toraja it is the opposite of neglect.

2. Living With a Roommate Who Practices It

If my roommate came from a Toraja family, I would want them to tell me about it, but only if they felt comfortable. I would probably feel uneasy at first, and I would not pretend otherwise to myself. Still, that unease comes from how I was raised, not from any proof that the practice is wrong. Ethnocentrism means judging another culture by my own standards, and cultural relativism means trying to understand a practice within its own context. I lean toward the second, because the families involved describe the ritual as love and responsibility toward people they miss. My own value of respecting family, which I share with them, is the same value expressed in a very different form.

Respect does have limits, though. I would still care about everyone's rights and safety, so I would expect no human remains in our living space and no pressure on me to take part. Those are practical boundaries, and a roommate agreement can cover them. Asking questions with real curiosity would help us more than avoiding the subject, and it would show that I see them as a person and not as a stereotype. If they preferred not to share, I would accept that too.

3. The Speech

I would give an informative speech, not a persuasive one. My goal would be to help the audience understand Ma'nene, not to convince them to adopt it or to defend every part of it. Advocacy would be inappropriate because I am an outsider, my classmates did not choose to be recruited,

and the practice carries real questions about consent, tourism, and religious change that the Toraja themselves debate. An ethical speaker should be honest about those complications and avoid pushing a conclusion the evidence does not require. Audience analysis points the same way. Most of my classmates will probably be Americans who find the topic unsettling, so I should start from what we share: every culture has a way to remember the dead.

For visual aids, I would use a map of Sulawesi, a simple timeline or diagram showing the steps of the ritual, and a photo of the traditional tongkonan houses and stone tombs. I would only show images that the families agreed to share publicly and that come from credited sources. I would avoid close-up photos of bodies, since they would shock the audience and take attention away from the meaning of the ritual. I would also add a comparison slide showing an American funeral custom next to Ma'nene, so the audience sees both as ways of grieving.

For language, I would use calm, neutral, and respectful wording. I would say “remains,” “ancestors,” and “families,” not words like “creepy,” “bizarre,” or “weird.” I would also avoid describing the Toraja as “primitive” or treating them as one single group, because practices differ between villages. I would explain terms like Aluk Todolo and patane (the family grave houses) simply, cite my sources aloud, and invite questions at the end.

References

Parameswara, A. (2015, November 3). *Bringing out the dead*. Roads & Kingdoms.

<https://roadsandkingdoms.com/2015/bringing-out-the-dead/>

Putra, A. S., Hijjang, P., & Tang, M. (2023). Ethnographic study of symbolic meanings in the Ma'nene' Toraja ritual series. *Journal of Asian Multicultural Research for Social Sciences Study*, 4(2), 73-78. <https://doi.org/10.47616/jamrsss.v4i2.436>